

CHAPTER 1

THE DATING GAME

If you've read my previous books, you know my mother, Georgette, was a financial wunderkind. She took over the family clothing business at a young age and, through careful money management and smart investing, was able to amass a small fortune. She survived the premature death of my father, Terry, whose "life of the party" personality disintegrated into serious money problems a few years into their marriage. But when my mother married for the second time, she did things differently. She readjusted her criteria and learned from her mistakes, revamping her entire approach to choosing a life partner. The change came partly out of necessity—this time, she had to think about what was best for her two children, my brother, Shane, and me—and partly out of a desire to build a marriage and a family that would last.

And last it did. Georgette married my stepfather, George, in 1962, and they forged a happy, healthy, secure partnership that continued until my mother's death in 2008. How many people can claim 46 years of wedded bliss? Not many, according to the statistics. A recent study showed more than one-third of marriages end in divorce before the 30th anniversary. That's a lot of broken hearts and a lot of thin wallets.